

ANI

NEERU WON TWO GOLD MEDALS AT THE ASIAN GAMES IN JAPAN—FIRST IN THE WOMEN'S INDIVIDUAL EVENT AND THEN IN THE MIXED TEAM EVENT

When Neeru Dhanda was born in Sangatpura village in Haryana's Jind district, her *nani* (maternal grandmother) cried, worrying about how her daughter, Sudesh, would manage after giving birth to her second girl child. Twenty-six years later, that same girl is being heralded as the "Laxmi" of the household after her exploits with the shotgun in 2026. First came the ISSF World Cup gold at Lonato, Italy, in July, where she beat an elite field of Olympic and world champions to win the women's trap title. Then came two gold medals and a silver at the recently concluded Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan—gold in the individual event and then the mixed team event with Kynan Chenai, with both finals producing new Games records, and silver in the women's team event.

Neeru never asked much from her family apart from "freedom". It saw her leave her home at age 11 and stay in hostels while studying in government schools. "I became wiser and more aware of life's hard truths at a young age," she says. Later, she lived with her maternal uncle Somveer and his family in Faridabad for a year and a half, where her cousin Lakshay Sheoran, a trap shooter himself, would inspire her to take up shooting. "If they weren't there, then I wouldn't be where I am today," says Neeru. "Lakshay's mother endured a lot for me. After I won gold, she said, '*Yeh hui baat*'."

By 19, Neeru moved to the Madhya Pradesh State Shooting Academy in Bhopal to take up the sport professionally. It is here that she found a coach and mentor in Mansher Singh as well as top-notch facilities. "I felt god has chosen the right place for me," she says. "I went in with a whole new confidence *ki achhi life jeeyungi aage* [that I'll live a good life from here on]."

The academy gave her wings, which is why she describes the state's former sports minister Yashodhara Raje Scindia, who was instrumental in setting up the academy, as her "second mother". "We spoke for 20 minutes on the phone after I won gold," she says. But the real force driving her all along was her mother, Sudesh. "*Maa ka sapna tha* [It was my mother's dream] that I stand on the podium with the tricolour," says Neeru. "Her desire was my motivation. She has struggled a lot, but she's a strong woman. She told me that she'd take care of everything and asked me to focus on my training."

When Neeru won gold, her mother was not at home to celebrate. She was standing in a Below Poverty Line (BPL) queue to collect the family's ration. Neeru now feels it is her turn to reward her mother and ease the family's hardships. "*Jo mehnat se kama ke*